

Technophilia, Technophobia, and Cransberg's Law

Thesis: The dominant public discourse on technology suffers from contradictory moralizing (technophilia and technophobia), a flawed understanding of "progress," and a tendency to apply a "scapegoat" model, thereby preventing effective ethical engagement. A more nuanced perspective is required, as articulated by Cransberg's Law, which states that "technology is neither good, nor bad, nor neutral" [1].

Key Concepts and Models:

• **Technophilia & Technophobia:**

- The core problem is not a lack of ethics for technology, but rather "too much" moralizing about artefacts (technological objects) [2]. We constantly moralize about artefacts and technology [3].

- This leads to a **"moral panic"** where we simultaneously assume technophilia and technophobia, creating a system of contradictory values that "doesn't work" [4, 5].

- **Technophilia:** * Refers to an **overly positive enthusiasm for technology**, particularly new technology [3, 5]. * It is the belief that technology will inevitably bring benefits, such as medicine curing all ailments or a new iPhone bringing happiness [3]. * More precisely, technophilia means **"considering, first of all, in an artefact, its good affordances"** [5]. * An **"affordance"** is an important concept in the philosophy of technology, referring to **"what the object allows you to do"** or "what it gives you the capacity to do" [6]. For example, a phone's affordance allows you to talk to someone far away [6]. Some affordances are useful, beautiful, pleasant, or gratifying [7].

- **Technophobia:** * Refers to an **overly pessimistic despair or fear for technology**, especially a new technology [3, 7]. * It involves fears that technology will have negative impacts, such as industry making life impossible on the planet, or social media making children "stupid, unsatisfied, vulnerable" [3, 4]. * More precisely, technophobia means **"considering, first of all, in an artefact, its bad affordances"** [7]. * Artefacts typically have many affordances, some good and some bad [8]. The example of a knife illustrates this: it has good affordances like cooking or working on an animal's skin, and bad ones like killing or threatening people [8]. * It is futile to try and invent a "knife that can cut bread but not the belly of the infinite," implying we cannot design technology to have only good affordances [9]. * We should also avoid equating the technology itself (e.g., "knife," "screen," "smartphone") with its "vicious use" or "pernicious use," which are specific cases. The problem lies in the particular application, not the tool universally [10, 11].

• **The Progress Model:**

- **Thesis:** "Progress is a myth, but a good one" [12, 13].

- Historically, from the Gospel through the 19th and early 20th centuries, Western civilization held a consensual belief that science and progress would bring universal benefits to humanity [12].

- This belief was an **anomaly**; ancient and classical cultures (Western and Chinese) traditionally linked respect and admiration to the past, viewing "new" as "perverse, dangerous, suspect" and "ancient" as "valid" until the Renaissance [14, 15].

- Today, we no longer believe progress is guaranteed; it must be **verified case-by-case**, and "progress" is no longer synonymous with "better" [14].

- Despite this, progress remains a **fundamental mythology** of our civilization, driving beliefs in scientific, industrial, and medical advancement, political organizations, judicial systems, and even moral progress (e.g., values of childhood, sexual equality) [16, 17].

- Believing in a common mythology can be beneficial for society by fostering shared values and common goals [17]. However, philosophy requires more than common belief; it requires **ethics** [13].

• The Scapegoat Model:

- **Thesis:** This model describes a "negative train of thought" where an innocent entity is symbolically blamed for all societal "sins" and "punished" (e.g., exiled or killed), allowing the community to feel absolved without addressing the real problems [18, 19].

- This archaic and powerful structure is found in various contexts, including religion (e.g., Christianity) [19].

- **Application to Technology:** Technology is frequently made a scapegoat [20]. Examples include: * The Internet being blamed for pornography, abuse, radicalization, and terrorism [20]. An anecdote highlights a Swiss article on "dangers of child abuse on the Internet" despite no actual cases being reported in that canton [21, 22]. * Social media (e.g., Facebook) being blamed for the dereliction of family life or social conversation [22]. * Artificial intelligence (AI) being blamed for job loss or the "eradication of humanity" [22].

- **The Core Problem:** The scapegoat model, beyond being untrue or unfair, **prevents real problems from being addressed** [23]. By focusing all attention and moralizing on the technological scapegoat, the actual underlying issues (e.g., frequent child abuse occurring offline within families) are ignored or misunderstood [23, 24].

• Cransberg's Law:

- **Thesis:** "Technology is neither good, nor bad, nor neutral" [1].

- **Explanation:** * Technology is not inherently "good" (e.g., a knife can kill) [1, 25]. * Technology is not inherently "bad" (e.g., a knife is useful, tools were necessary for humanization) [25]. Even atomic weapons, while often perceived as intrinsically bad, are seen by military and geostrategic experts as having prevented a large-scale war during the Cold War, demonstrating a non-totally negative impact [25-27]. * The crucial point is that technology is also **not neutral** [1].

- This law emphasizes a more nuanced approach to technology, recognizing its dual potential and rejecting simplistic moral judgments [1].